



A NEW FRONTIER (Clockwise from left) *120 Bahadur*, *Battle of Galwan* and *Tere Ishk Mein*

as well as explorations of the battalion archives. The narrative that emerged is racy, politically nuanced and packed with enough intimate exchanges to distinguish it from the usual jingoism of Indian war dramas.

But this is not the only recent Bollywood project that has turned its nationalistic gaze away from India's favourite punching bag, Pakistan. China also features in the romantic drama *Tere Ishk Mein*, starring Dhanush and Kriti Sanon, in which the former plays an air force pilot. The latest season of Amazon Prime's *Family Man* travels to Northeast India and concocts China's Project Guan Yu, that seeks to create unrest in India with the establishment of phoenix villages on the Indo-Myanmar border. Next year will also see Salman Khan don army fatigues and give the Chinese a fitting reply for their 2020 incursions in the *Battle of Galwan*.

LOOKING EAST

Boredom, for the most part, drives this resurgent interest in China apropos Indian war dramas. "We have gotten bored of the India-Pak narrative," says Ghai. "Pakistan you can keep bashing. Every two years, there's a film on [battling] Pakistan," says retired Lieutenant General Rakesh Sharma, former GoC of the Leh-based 14 Corp. (The recent *Dhurandhar* and upcoming *Border 2* are the latest in that bandwagon). Lt Gen Sharma believes China is no easy neighbour to live with which is why he is glad a film like *120 Bahadur* is being made, which, he says, "ought to have been shown long ago."

The crew on such projects is pleased too, as the cornucopia of new stories means there is the exciting creative opportunity of filming in locations like Ladakh and the North East. Since the 1962 war, India has had many border incidents with China in territories from Arunachal Pradesh to Sikkim to Ladakh. Though war dramas featuring Pakistan have involved gritty scenes of militancy or terrorism in Kashmir, China as the on-screen enemy gives cinematographers the chance to up the ante with a formidable army on the other side of no man's land.

There are many stories that can be mined for future projects, too. Lt Gen Sharma points to Major Dhan Singh Thapa, who commanded the first battalion of the 8th Gurkhas regiment in the early days of the 1962 war. Chinese forces surrounded Thapa's men at a post near Pangong Lake (spanning Ladakh and Tibet) and were repelled many times over before finally overrunning his forces and capturing the post. A prisoner through the one-month war, Thapa was celebrated for his efforts upon returning to India



"INDIA AND CHINA'S RELATIONSHIP IS PRECARIOUS. THE COUNTRY IS POWERFUL AND WE HAVE $120 BILLION WORTH OF TRADE WITH THEM. IF BOLLYWOOD STARTS MAKING MORE ANTI-CHINESE FILMS, THEY WILL NOT BUY THEM"

LT GEN (RETD) RAKESH SHARMA
Former GoC of Leh-based 14 Corp

